Vision-Based Hand Gesture Recognition for Assistive Computing

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Abstract—Assistive human–computer interaction remains a critical challenge for individuals with speech impairments, as most existing systems rely on speech, text, or specialized hardware that limits accessibility and real-time usability. This paper presents a vision-based, AI-driven framework for real-time hand gesture recognition aimed at enabling natural and accessible computer interaction for users worldwide. The proposed system employs a deep learning–based convolutional neural network trained on a large-scale public hand gesture dataset comprising 26 distinct gesture classes. The trained model is integrated with an OpenCV-based real-time inference pipeline that processes live video streams captured from a standard RGB camera, enabling immediate gesture recognition without the need for specialized sensors or wearable devices. Extensive experimental evaluation demonstrates strong classification performance, achieving high overall accuracy and robust macro-averaged precision, recall, and F1-score across all gesture classes. The results indicate that the system is effective for real-time assistive interaction, offering a low-cost, scalable, and practical solution for vision-based and touchless computer interaction.

Index Terms—Hand Gesture Recognition, Assistive Computing, Human–Computer Interaction, Deep Learning, Convolutional Neural Networks, Computer Vision, Real-Time Inference, OpenCV, Accessibility Technologies.

I. Introduction

Human–computer interaction (HCI) enables communication between users and digital systems; however, widely adopted interaction modalities such as speech, keyboards, and touch-based interfaces are not universally accessible [1]. For many users and individuals with speech impairments, these methods can be restrictive, cognitively demanding, or physically inaccessible [2]. Hand gesture–based interaction offers a more natural and comfortable alternative, particularly for users who rely on gestural communication in daily life [3]. This intuitive paradigm is also well suited for individuals who experience difficulty adapting to complex interfaces, including elderly users and those with additional motor, sensory, or cognitive limitations. Consequently, continued reliance on traditional input mechanisms restricts independent access in computing technologies and limits participation in education, employment, and everyday digital activities.

Recent advances in deep learning and computer vision have significantly improved vision-based hand gesture recognition, enabling accurate interaction using standard RGB cameras without specialized sensors or wearables [4]–[19]. This progress supports scalable and rapid deployment and can increase accessibility, particularly in assistive computing contexts where sensitive, real-time interaction can promote digital inclusion. However, many existing systems remain limited by hardware dependencies, insufficient real-time validation, or poor generalization across users and environments [20]–[30]. Addressing these challenges is essential to enable practical, inclusive gesture-based interaction for main users.

Prior research spans sensor-based approaches [8], hand-crafted vision methods [3], and deep learning–driven techniques [31]. While sensor-based systems often achieve high accuracy, their reliance on specialized hardware restricts scalability. Vision-based methods [15], supported by convolutional neural networks, offer greater accessibility but still face challenges related to robustness, scalability, and real-time performance [9]–[19]. Consequently, there remains a need for accessible, end-to-end vision based solutions that support reliable real-time interaction using standard camera devices.

To address the limitations of existing assistive interaction systems, this paper proposes a vision-based, AI-driven framework for real-time hand gesture recognition (Figure 1) to enable natural, contactless interaction for main users. The primary focus of this work is the design, training, and real-time validation of a deep learning–based gesture recognition model



Fig. 1. Vision-based real-time hand gesture recognition enabling touchless assistive interaction with smart home devices using a camera-based interface.

that operates exclusively on visual input from a standard RGB camera. This approach eliminates the need for specialized sensors, wearable devices, or constrained environments. By leveraging advances in deep learning and computer vision, the proposed model can accurately recognize hand gestures and provide immediate feedback during real-time interaction.

While Fig. 1 illustrates a broader assistive interaction scenario, including smart home control, the integration with smart environments and the development of a complete system interface are beyond the scope of this paper and are presented solely for conceptual demonstration of potential applications.

A key distinguishing aspect of the proposed framework is its end-to-end integration of model training, validation, and real-time deployment. The trained recognition model is directly incorporated into a real-time inference pipeline, allowing gesture identification to be performed continuously on live video streams. This design ensures practical usability while maintaining scalability and accessibility. Unlike many existing solutions that focus primarily on offline evaluation, the proposed system emphasizes real-time assistive interaction, demonstrating its effectiveness in practical scenarios and its potential for deployment in everyday environments.

The main contributions of this work are as follows: (1) the development of a deep learning–based hand gesture recognition model trained on a large public dataset comprising 26 gesture classes, (2) the design of an end-to-end pipeline that integrates data preprocessing, training, validation, and real-time inference using OpenCV, (3) a comprehensive experimental evaluation employing multiple performance metrics, including accuracy, macro-F1, balanced accuracy, confusion matrices, and per-class analysis, and (4) the demonstration of a real-time assistive interaction prototype that validates practical usability for main users without requiring retraining or specialized hardware.

The remaining part of this paper is organized as follows. Section II presents the background and related work. Section III details dataset description, preprocessing, the proposed model architecture, and training procedures. Section IV reports experimental evaluation and quantitative results. Finally, Section V concludes the paper and highlights future work.

II. Background and Related Work

Gesture-based human–computer interaction has emerged as an important paradigm for enabling natural and non-verbal communication between users and digital systems. Unlike traditional interaction modalities, such as speech or text input, gestures provide an intuitive means of expression that aligns closely with human communication behaviors. This intuitive paradigm is particularly relevant for assistive computing, where users with speech or hearing impairments may rely primarily on hand gestures for communication. As a result, gesture recognition has been widely studied as a foundational component of accessible and inclusive human–computer interaction systems. Existing research can be broadly grouped into three main categories: vision-based gesture recognition systems, sensor-based wearable systems, and alternative assistive sensing approaches. Each category presents distinct trade-offs in terms of robustness, privacy, hardware requirements, and computational complexity.

A. Vision-Based Gesture Recognition Approaches

Early vision-based gesture recognition systems for smart home control relied primarily on classical computer vision techniques and handcrafted features. Somasegaran and Kavuvanthodi [20] proposed a robust vision-based hand gesture recognition system designed for complex home environments. Their approach combined Viola–Jones object detection for hand localization with skin color segmentation in the YCbCr color space and translation, rotation, and scale-invariant (TRS)-assisted features. A multilayer perceptron classifier was used to recognize gestures, achieving reliable performance even in cluttered backgrounds. However, the system required multiple preprocessing stages and remained sensitive to poor lighting conditions and larger motion during segmentation.

Several studies extended vision-based gesture control using smaller camera-centric pipelines. Kinesi hand system leveraged depth sensing and skeleton tracking to improve robustness against background clutter and illumination changes. A multimodal smart home system integrating Kinect-based gesture recognition with voice control for impaired users was presented in [6], demonstrating improved accessibility through multiple interaction modalities. Similarly, a Kinect hand approach using Hidden Markov Models (HMMs) was proposed in [18], enabling temporal modeling of gesture sequences. Despite their robustness, Kinect hand solutions depend on specialized hardware, require hand placement and line-of-sight operation, and constrain user distance and positioning.

With advances in deep learning, neural networks has shifted toward convolutional neural network (CNN)–based gesture recognition. A lightweight MobileNetV2-based vision system for static hand gesture recognition was presented in [7], achieving very high classification accuracy while maintaining low computational complexity and suitability for resource-constrained devices. More recent work explored enhanced CNN architectures enhanced with attention mechanisms, such as Efficient Channel Attention (ECA) and Squeeze-and-Excitation (SE) blocks, to improve feature discrimination in complex environments [31]. While these deep learning approaches significantly improve recognition accuracy, they still inherit core limitations of vision-based systems, including privacy concerns, reliance on camera configuration, and sensitivity to environmental conditions such as lighting variation, and camera viewpoint.

Vision-based gesture recognition in dynamic and complicated environments has also been studied in [21], where data-safety detection and pilot-centric hand monitoring were used to recognize hand gestures under background motion and partial occlusion. Although effective, such systems increase algorithmic complexity and still depend on favorable lighting and camera placement.

complex of selected gesture classes, including A, B, L, and Y, arranged from top to bottom.

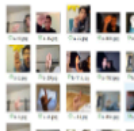


Fig. 2. Sample hand gesture images from the ASL dataset illustrating representative classes.

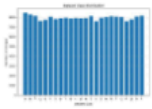


Fig. 3. Distribution of images across the 26 gesture classes used for training and validation.

The dataset was divided into training and validation subsets using an 80/20 split. The training subset was used to optimize model parameters, while the validation subset was reserved for monitoring generalization performance during training.

Prior to training, all images underwent a lightweight preprocessing pipeline to ensure consistent input representation. Each image was resized to 160 × 160 pixels, matching the input requirements of the adopted MobileNetV2 architecture. Pixel values were then normalized using the same preprocessing function employed during model training to maintain consistency between training and inference. No explicit background subtraction, hand segmentation, or handcrafted feature extraction was applied. Instead, the convolutional neural network was allowed to automatically learn discriminative spatial features directly from raw image data, leveraging its hierarchical feature extraction capability.

B. AI Model Architecture and Training

The proposed hand gesture recognition system employs a Convolutional Neural Network (CNN) implemented using TensorFlow and Keras. Input images are resized to 160 × 160 pixels and processed in batches of 32 samples during training. The model is optimized using the Adam optimizer with a learning rate of 0.001, and categorical cross-entropy is used as the loss function. To mitigate overfitting and preserve the best-performing model, early stopping and model checkpointing mechanisms are applied during training.

As illustrated in Figure 3, the proposed architecture is built upon MobileNetV2, which serves as a lightweight feature extractor pretrained on large-scale image datasets. The pretrained backbone outputs a feature map of size 5 × 5 × 1280, which is subsequently processed using a global average pooling layer to reduce spatial dimensionality while preserving semantic information. This is followed by a fully connected layer with 128 neurons and ReLU activation, a dropout layer (rate = 0.5) to improve generalization, and a final softmax classification



Fig. 4. Dedicated architecture of the proposed MobileNetV2-based gesture recognition model. The network processes a 160×160×3 RGB input image, applies feature extraction using a pretrained backbone, and outputs class probabilities for 26 hand gestures.

layer with 26 output neurons, corresponding to the gesture classes.

The MobileNetV2 backbone is frozen during training, allowing the model to leverage robust pretrained representations while reducing computational cost and training time. This design choice is particularly suitable for real-time gesture recognition systems, where efficiency and responsiveness are critical. The complete model was trained for 10 epochs, achieving strong generalization performance without overfitting.

In this work, a pretrained MobileNetV2 architecture is employed as the feature extraction backbone for the proposed hand gesture recognition system. The original classification layers of MobileNetV2 are removed, and the convolutional base is kept frozen during training to preserve previously learned low- and mid-level visual features such as edges, contours, and hand shape patterns. This strategy enables efficient transfer learning while reducing computational cost and minimizing the risk of overfitting.

Following the convolutional backbone, a Global Average Pooling (GAP) layer is applied to compress spatial feature maps into a compact feature representation. This is followed by a fully connected layer with 128 neurons and ReLU activation, which allows the network to learn task-specific discriminative representations. A dropout layer with a rate of 0.5 is then introduced to improve generalization by reducing co-adaptation among neurons. Finally, a softmax output layer with 26 neurons produces class probability distributions corresponding to the 26 static ASL gesture classes.

The model is trained using the Adam optimization algorithm with a learning rate of 0.001, providing stable and efficient convergence. Categorical cross-entropy is employed as the loss function, as the gesture labels are represented using one-hot encoding. Model performance is evaluated using classification accuracy, which reflects the proportion of correctly predicted gestures across all classes.

Training is conducted for 10 epochs using a batch size of 32. During training, the dataset is processed in mini-batches to ensure computational efficiency and stable gradient updates. Validation performance is monitored at each epoch to assess generalization behavior. The training curves indicate rapid convergence, with validation accuracy stabilizing early during training, indicating effective feature reuse from the pretrained backbone.

Overall, the proposed architecture achieves a strong balance between recognition accuracy, computational efficiency, and architectural simplicity. These properties make the system well suited for real-time gesture recognition in assistive and interactive environments, where low latency and reliable performance are essential.

C. Real-Time Inference and System Configuration

This subsection describes the real-time inference pipeline used for live gesture recognition. The system is implemented in Python, utilizing OpenCV for video capture and visualization, and TensorFlow/Keras for model inference.



Fig. 5. Real-time gesture recognition system interface showing live prediction output.

Figure 4 illustrates the integration of the trained model within the real-time inference pipeline. The trained model is first loaded from disk using the load_model() function, ensuring that the same learned weights obtained during training are reused during deployment. The input image resolution is fixed at 160 × 160 pixels, matching the training configuration and ensuring consistent feature representation between training and inference. A predefined list of 26 gesture class labels is used to map predicted class indices to human-readable gesture names.

Live video input is acquired through a webcam using OpenCV's VideoCapture interface. Each video frame is processed independently, enabling frame-based inference without temporal dependency. To maintain stable performance and reduce computational overhead, the system enforces a fixed inference rate of 15 frames per second (FPS). This is achieved through a time-based throttling mechanism that processes a frame only when the elapsed time exceeds a predefined interval ($1 / \text{TARGET_FPS}$).

Prior to inference, each captured frame undergoes a preprocessing pipeline consistent with the training phase. The frame is converted from BGR to RGB color space, resized to 160 × 160 pixels, and normalized using the same preprocessing function (mobilenet_v2.preprocess_input) applied during train-

Table I summarizes the quantitative performance of the proposed gesture recognition model across multiple evaluation metrics. The model achieves an overall accuracy of 96.11 %. The Matthews Correlation Coefficient (0.9616) and Cohen's Kappa (0.9555) indicate strong agreement between predicted and ground-truth labels, demonstrating robust classification performance beyond chance-level agreement. While the Top 3 and Top 5 accuracies are relatively low, this is expected given the fine-grained nature of hand gesture classification and the strict class separation required in assistive interaction tasks. The log-loss value of 15.0456 reflects the model's confidence in its classification probabilities.

Overall, these results indicate that the proposed model achieves reliable and well-balanced performance across multiple evaluation criteria, supporting its suitability for real-time vision-based gesture recognition in assistive human–computer interaction environments.

Overall, the proposed model demonstrates strong generalization capability and stable convergence behavior. The consistently high validation accuracy and low loss values confirm the effectiveness of the selected architecture, training strategy, and preprocessing pipeline. To further analyze class-level performance and identify potential misclassification patterns, a confusion matrix analysis is presented in the following subsection.

B. Confusion Matrix Analysis

The confusion matrix provides a detailed evaluation of the model's classification performance across all gesture classes. As shown in Figure 6, the normalized confusion matrix exhibits strong diagonal dominance, indicating that the majority of samples are correctly classified with high confidence. This confirms the model's strong discriminative capability across the 26 gesture classes.

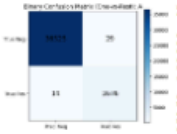


Fig. 6. Normalized confusion matrix illustrating classification performance across all gesture classes.

Only minor misclassifications are observed, primarily among visually similar gestures, which is expected in vision-

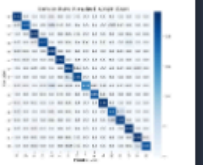


Fig. 7. Confusion matrix visualization for selected gesture classes (A–I) including O.

Overall, the confusion matrix analysis confirms the robustness and generalization capability of the proposed model. The strong diagonal dominance and limited off-diagonal activations demonstrate effective feature learning and reliable gesture discrimination, supporting the suitability of the system for real-time human–computer interaction applications.

C. Per-Class Performance

Per-class precision, recall, and F1-score were computed to provide a detailed evaluation of the model's classification behavior across individual gesture categories. These metrics offer deeper insight beyond overall accuracy by quantifying how well each gesture is recognized and distinguished from others.

As shown in Figure 11, the model achieves consistently high performance across all gesture classes, with most classes exhibiting F1-scores above 0.95. This indicates strong class-wise generalization and balanced prediction behavior. Precision and recall values remain uniformly high, demonstrating

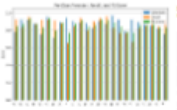


Fig. 8. Per-class precision, recall, and F1-score for the 26 gesture classes.

that the model effectively minimizes both false positives and false negatives across the gesture set.

Minor variations are observed among visually similar gestures, which is expected due to subtle similarities in hand shape and orientation. For instance, the gesture V was misclassified as gesture U in 2 instances (approximately 0.9%) compared to other classes; however, this value remains exceptionally low and does not significantly affect overall system reliability. Importantly, no gesture class exhibits systematic degradation in performance, confirming the robustness and consistency of the learned feature representations.

Overall, the per-class evaluation results demonstrate that the proposed model maintains stable and balanced recognition performance across all gesture categories, further validating its suitability for real-time assistive interaction and accessible human–computer interaction applications.

D. Vision-Based Real-Time Gesture Recognition System

In addition to offline evaluation, the trained model was integrated into a real-time gesture recognition system to assess system-level performance under live operating conditions. The system acquires a continuous video stream using a standard deep learning model to enable real-time gesture recognition. The implementation is built using Python, with OpenCV handling video capture and visualization, and TensorFlow/Keras performing inference.

During live operation, video frames are continuously captured from the camera and processed independently. Each frame is preprocessed to match the input requirements of the model before being passed to the trained model for inference. To ensure stable and consistent performance, inference is performed at a controlled rate of approximately 5 frames per second, and a time-based throttling mechanism is employed to skip excess frames. This approach reduces computational overhead while maintaining low latency.

The predicted gesture label is overlaid directly on the video stream along with the associated confidence score, providing immediate visual feedback to the user. Figure 12 presents example screenshots of the system during live operation, illustrating accurate gesture recognition and stable real-time performance. The consistent visual response demonstrates the system's ability to operate reliably in interactive environments.

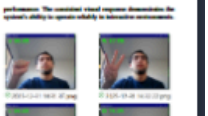


Fig. 10. Real-time gesture recognition system running live operation.

In addition to on-screen visualization, the system was integrated with a text-to-speech module to enhance feedback for main communication, enabling gesture-based control of physical outputs such as LEDs. This integration demonstrates the practicality of the proposed framework for real-world assistive and smart environment applications. The system maintained stable performance under varying lighting conditions, with minor reductions in confidence observed under low-light scenarios, which can be addressed through exposure adjustment or additional training.

Overall, the real-time deployment validates that the proposed model generalizes well beyond offline evaluation. Its low computational overhead, stable inference behavior, and reliable performance make it suitable for integration into assistive technologies, touchless interfaces, and smart human–computer interaction and assistive technology applications.

V. Conclusion and Future Work

This paper presented a robust vision-based hand gesture recognition system designed for real-time assistive interaction applications. By leveraging a deep learning framework and integrating a MobileNetV2-based convolutional neural network with an efficient real-time inference pipeline, enabling accurate gesture recognition using standard RGB camera input. The system demonstrates a complete workflow ranging from image preprocessing and preprocessing to classification and real-time visual feedback.

Experimental results confirm the effectiveness of the proposed model. Using an 80/20 training–validation split, the system achieves a validation accuracy of approximately 95.6% across 26 static ASL gesture classes, with a corresponding low validation loss. This high classification performance, supported by strong per-class precision, recall, and F1 scores, demonstrates the model's ability to generalize effectively across diverse hand gestures and visual conditions. The use of a lightweight MobileNetV2 backbone enables efficient inference while maintaining strong classification capability.

The real-time inference pipeline further demonstrates the practicality of the proposed system. By processing video frames at a controlled rate of approximately 5 frames per second, the system achieves stable and responsive gesture recognition suitable for interactive applications. The integration of real-time visualization, confidence scoring, and efficient frame processing highlights the feasibility of deploying the model in practical assistive scenarios, including touchless interfaces and smart home control or accessibility tools.

While the current system performs reliably under standard lighting and controlled environmental conditions, performance may degrade under extreme illumination changes, occlusions, or complex backgrounds. Future work will focus on improving temporal modeling techniques, such as temporal smoothing or sequence-based architectures, to improve robustness for continuous gesture recognition. Additional directions include expanding the gesture vocabulary, incorporating dynamic two-hand gestures, and evaluating performance under diverse real-world conditions. These enhancements aim to further improve the robustness and practical applicability in broader assistive and interactive environments.

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B. Sensor-Based Wearable Gesture Recognition

To overcome the inherent limitations of camera-based systems, sensor-based wearable gesture recognition has gained increasing attention. These approaches typically employ inertial measurement units (IMUs) to capture hand or wrist motion directly, making them immune to lighting conditions, background clutter, and camera positioning. Woods and Hernandez [22] proposed one of the earliest wearable smart home gesture recognition systems for smart home control using an MPU6050 IMU and HOPE microcontroller. Their system utilized Naïve Bayesian for training and deploying a lightweight neural network model capable of performing offline inference on embedded hardware. By employing HSP 46/48 for peer-to-peer communication, the system achieved low latency, cloud-free operation while preserving user privacy. Experimental results demonstrated high validation accuracy and reliable real-time performance, highlighting the suitability of IMU-based approaches for assistive applications targeting elderly or physically disabled users.

Sensor-based gesture recognition has also been explored in broader human–computer interaction contexts, demonstrating advantages such as low power consumption, and time-stamped motion data in environmental variability. However, wearable systems require users to wear dedicated hardware, which may inconvenience in certain scenarios compared to passive camera-based interaction.

C. Alternative Non-Vision Sensing Approaches

Beyond vision- and IMU-based methods, alternative sensing modalities have been investigated for gesture recognition in smart homes. A respiratory-based gesture recognition system using ultra-wideband (UWB) measurements was proposed in [23]. By modeling gesture trajectories derived from UWB localization data and classifying them using a deep learning model, the system achieved high recognition accuracy while remaining robust to user orientation and distance. This approach also preserves privacy by avoiding visual data capture. Nevertheless, UWB-based systems require specialized hardware infrastructure, which may increase deployment cost and complexity.

III. Methodology and System Pipeline

Building on the limitations identified in existing gesture-based interaction systems, this section presents the proposed methodology and system architecture for real-time hand gesture recognition. The focus of this work is on the design and deployment of a vision based. All-down recognition pipeline that operates using standard camera hardware and supports real-time user interaction. The proposed framework clearly separates offline learning components from online inference and interaction, enabling both robust model development and practical deployment. The following subsections describe the overall system pipeline, including data preparation, model training and validation, and the integration of the trained model into a real-time interface for interactive gesture recognition.

A. Dataset and Preprocessing

The experiments were conducted using a publicly available American Sign Language (ASL) hand gesture dataset obtained from Kaggle. The dataset consists of RGB images representing 26 distinct static hand gesture classes, corresponding to the English alphabet letters A–Z, excluding J and Z. These two letters are omitted because they involve dynamic motion patterns rather than static hand poses and are therefore not suitable for frame-based image classification without temporal modeling.

The dataset contains approximately 195,000 labeled images, captured under varying illumination conditions, hand orientations, and backgrounds, providing strong visual diversity for robust model training. Figure 3 illustrates representative

ing. The processed image is then expanded along the batch dimension and passed to the MobileNetV2 based model for prediction.

The model outputs a probability distribution over the 26 gesture classes. The class with the highest probability is selected as the predicted gesture, and its corresponding confidence score is extracted. This information is overlaid directly onto the live video stream using OpenCV's drawing utilities and rendered visual feedback in the user. Overall, this real-time inference design enables efficient, low-latency gesture recognition, making the system well-suited for interactive and assistive human–computer interaction applications.

IV. Experimental Evaluation and Results

This section presents an experimental evaluation of the proposed AI- vision based gesture recognition model comprising 26 gesture classes, using both offline quantitative metrics and a real-time OpenCV-based deployment. The model was trained for 10 epochs using an 80/20 training–validation split, achieving a final validation accuracy of approximately 95.6% with a corresponding validation loss of approximately 0.1611. The training accuracy converged to approximately 97.2%, indicating strong generalization performance.

Based on the recorded 1,581 training steps per epoch with a batch size of 32, the effective training set size is approximately 151,488 images, yielding an estimated total dataset size of approximately 195,000 images, with around 38,880 samples reserved for validation. These results demonstrate the robustness of the proposed model and its ability to learn discriminative gesture representations efficiently under realistic training conditions.

The results are organized into the following four subsections: (i) Quantitative Evaluation, (ii) Confusion Matrix Analysis, (iii) Per-Class Performance, and (iv) Vision-based Real-Time Gesture Recognition, covering overall learning behavior (accuracy and loss), detailed error analysis, per-class precision/recall/F1 trends, and live webcam inference performance.

A. Quantitative Evaluation

The proposed model achieved strong performance across multiple quantitative evaluation metrics, demonstrating its effectiveness for real-time hand gesture recognition. Using an 80/20 training–validation split, the model achieved a validation accuracy of approximately 95.6

To analyze the learning behavior and convergence characteristics of the model, training and validation accuracy were monitored across epochs, as shown in Figure 7. The training accuracy increases rapidly during the initial epochs, reflecting effective feature reuse through transfer learning with the MobileNetV2 backbone. The validation accuracy closely follows the training curve and stabilizes early in the training process, demonstrating consistent generalization and minimal overfitting.

To further assess optimization stability, training and validation loss curves were analyzed, as illustrated in Figure 8. The

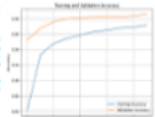


Fig. 9. Training and validation loss curves demonstrating stable convergence and minimal overfitting.

loss values decrease sharply during the initial training stages and converge smoothly to low values. The close alignment between training and validation loss curves indicates stable optimization behavior and effective generalization throughout the training process.



Fig. 8. Training and validation accuracy curves, showing rapid convergence and stable generalization performance.